Graphic Design

Advert Creation in Photoshop

Summary Notes

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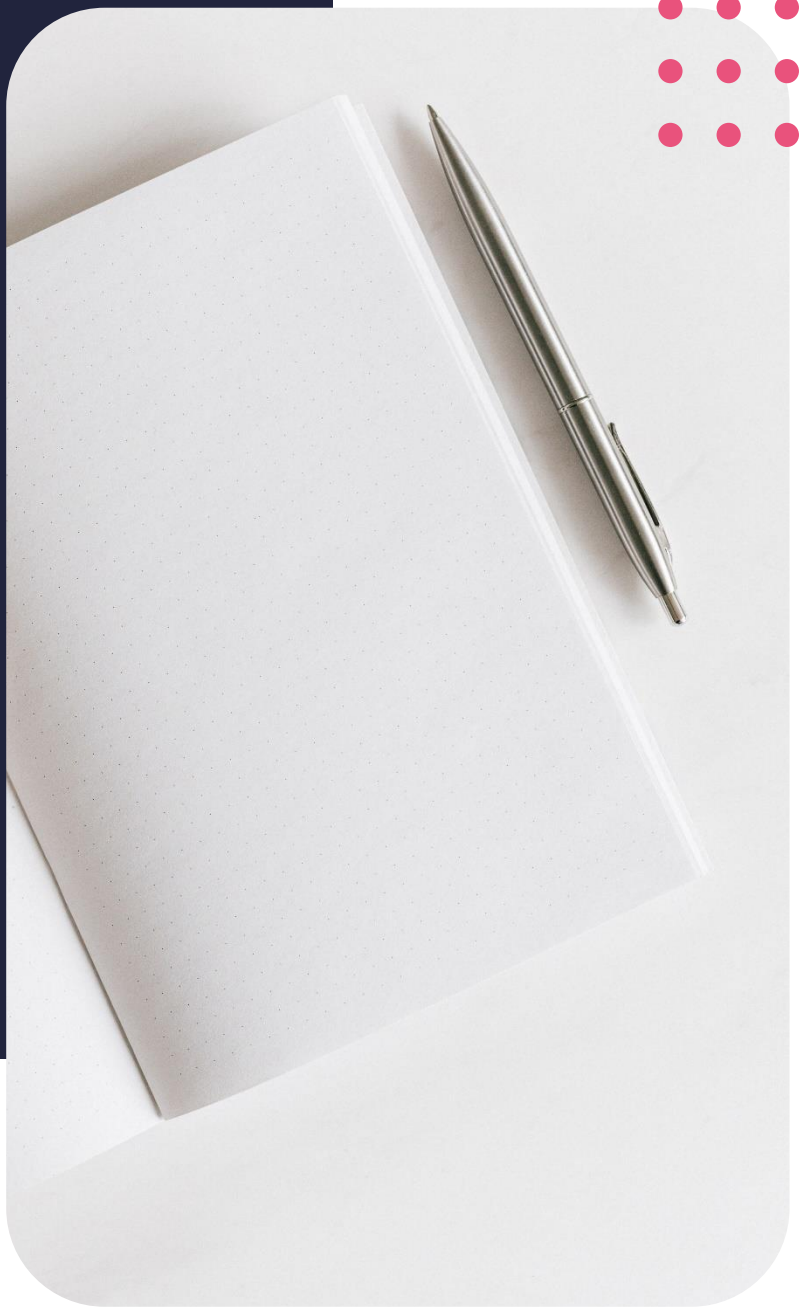


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

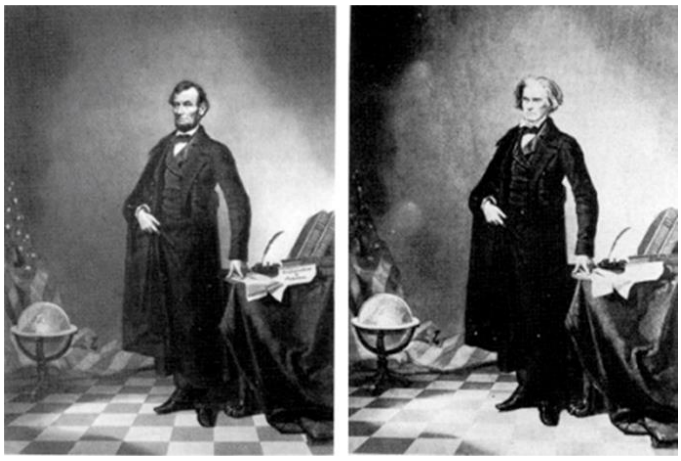
- Lesson outcome 1: Photo editing
- Lesson outcome 2: Photo manipulation & graphic design

Introduction

We will look at photomanipulation and enhancement specifically in today's lesson and then I will demonstrate the skills needed to manipulate and enhance your photographs in the form of an advertisement.

The history of manipulating photographs dates to as far as the 1860's – that's over 150 years ago! This is around 40 years after the first photograph was created.

In this photograph, President Abraham Lincoln's head is placed on politician John Calhoun's body. So, photo manipulation is not something that only came to existence during the digital age but has been done for well over a century.



Quoting artist, Andy Warhol, famous for his influence in the visual art movement known as pop art. "The best thing about a picture is that it never changes, even when the people in it do."

Unless, you're a graphic designer and manipulate a photograph for advertising purposes. So, where do we draw the line? How do we know whether a photograph has been manipulated or not?

Photo editing

There are so many factors to consider when manipulating photographs and sometimes, with a trained eye you can see when a photograph has been edited.

I would like to show you a couple of images and simply determine whether you think the photograph is manipulated or not. But before we get there, let's determine the difference between photo manipulation and enhancement.

When it comes to photo editing, we have two main techniques, photo enhancing and photo manipulation. What is the difference between enhancing and manipulation?

Photo enhancing

Enhancing a photograph is only a matter of improving the quality of a photograph by using basic adjustment techniques like increasing the lightness or darkness of a photograph, applying colour correction or adjusting the contrast of a photograph.

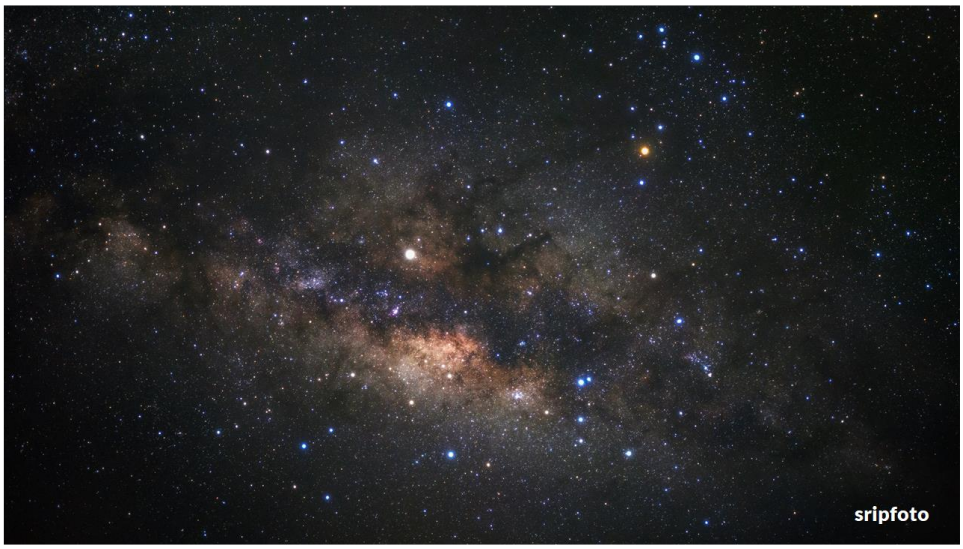
Enhancing of photographs are permitted for documentary styled photographs – photographs that still need to encapsulate the truth.

Photo manipulation

Photo manipulation on the other hand involves altering a photograph using a variety of methods to create an illusion or deception. In some cases, it can be used to create amazing digital art and in other instances, it is used to deceive the public. Photo manipulation can however be used for advertising or creative purposes albeit not always ethical.

As you have learnt from the previous lessons, we were able to manipulate photographs. The purpose of learning these techniques is to understand Photoshop and its amazing capabilities. I would however like to ask you to always consider your motifs for creating artwork and manipulating images. If done unethically, it can cause you a lot of damage and financial implications will be inevitable.

I would like to show you photographs and want you to identify whether the photograph is enhanced or manipulated.



An image of the milky way. Do you think this is a real photograph or do you think this is manipulated or enhanced only?

This image is only enhanced in bringing out the colours and increasing the contrast. The photograph is taken by sripfoto and he specialises in astrophotography.

The second image by tbarnadas is a surrealistic scene with a floating umbrella and a shark gaining on the floating umbrella. Obviously this is manipulated and done extremely well. It however does not fool the viewer in that you know this is not real. In this case, photo manipulation was used to create art.

What about this image by IM_photo? Is it in anyway manipulated or enhanced? This is a real photograph of earth from a near space perspective – 20km above ground to be exact. I'm sure that the artist enhanced the image but this is an actual photograph.

A photograph by journalist Narciso Contreras of a Syrian fighter under fire and taking cover. Do you think this photograph is manipulated or enhanced in any way? Perhaps you know the story behind this photograph.

Doing research, it was determined that this photograph was in fact manipulated. If you didn't know the story, you would not have known that this photograph has been manipulated.

ORIGINAL MANIPULATED

All Contreras did was to remove the video camera in the bottom left corner. It honestly doesn't seem like much and does not really affect the value of the photograph but since the reality of the photograph was manipulated, it immediately caused an uproar and unfortunately Contreras, being a world renown documentary photographer was sacked by the Associated press. Contreras admitted to making a big mistake and after examining almost 500 of his photographs, the Associated Press could not find any other examples of manipulation. One minor manipulation technique almost ruined his career. This is how strict documentary styled photographs are viewed.

Photo manipulation & graphic design

Understanding the difference between photo enhancing and manipulation, there is a fine line between what is right and wrong. I would suggest you trust your gut but just remember that doing something unethical can cost you a lot.

It is thus ok to manipulate photos when you create artwork or for advertising purposes. Simply removing an unwanted element from an image, like a blue plastic bag in the middle of the road falls under photo manipulation but don't mislead your audience. Also, with so much manipulating taking place, I am quite confident in saying that we all know that juicy burger you buy at McDonalds does not look like the advertisement you saw it in real life.

If you're not sure whether what you're doing is ethical, simply ask yourself if the item you are enhancing or removing will change the concept or story behind the photo. Like removing a pimple on a model's face – that pimple will not be there in a week's time, so is it unethical?

Anyways, I will be doing a brief demo on photo manipulation before we do our advertisement creation just to show you the awesome capabilities of Photoshop.

Refer to recording to view demo

Conclusion

Show us what you have learnt and design your own advert. Upload your artwork to your favourite social media channel. This was a look into photo editing using photoshop. To be truly great at photo editing, you will need to spend a lot of time and dedication in learning photoshop.

Our lesson today entailed examining the difference between photo enhancement and manipulation. We then did a demo on photomanipulation before we moved over to create an advert using photomanipulation techniques.